DECRIMINALISING HOMOSEXUALITY, 2018

FREEDOM TO LOVE

It's been only six years since the LGBTQ community got the Indian courts to rule that Section 377 was illegal, that they are not criminals and are free to love who they want. But the battle is still on to secure basic rights and a place in society free of stigma

BY SONALI ACHARJEE

Growing up in the 1950s, Anand Sharma (name changed), realised at a very young age that he had no choice but to pretend to be a heterosexual. "I was 14 when I knew I was attracted to men and not women but that same year I realised it was best not to speak about it. By the time I was in my early 20s, I knew I had to force myself to have sex with women if I wanted any social acceptance," he says. Today, aged 73, the Delhi-based former investment banker says he knows he can "come out of the closet" without any legal repercussions but his life has been built on so many lies that he cannot speak his truth without hurting a great number of people. "It is different for homosexuals growing up in today's world. I recently saw TV coverage of the Delhi Pride Parade and it warmed my heart to see such public display of affection between gays and lesbians. I am glad I got to see a world where there is acceptance for natural feelings," he says.



FREE AT LAST Hotelier Keshav Suri (left), one of the petitioners in the SC, with his husband after the court's ruling on gay rights, Sept. 6, 2018

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